

COMMUNICATION SKILLS # 16

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the relationship between addiction and partner relational conflicts.
2. Develop the skills necessary to maintain open and effective communication, sexual intimacy, and enjoyable time with a partner.
3. Identify ways the client currently succeeds and fails in sharing thoughts, feelings, or problems with others.
4. Identify better ways to communicate and learn to use them.
5. Learn to teach more effective communication strategies to others in the client's life and use them in those relationships.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PARTNER RELATIONAL CONFLICT

- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Creating a Family Ritual
- Forming Stable Relationships
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Identifying Proven Problem-Solving Skills
- Is It Romance or Is It Fear?
- Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?
- Learning to Ask Instead of Demand
- Negotiating Skills for Success
- Respect or Fear?
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The "Communication Skills" activity is intended for clients whose relationships are -troubled due to poor communication skills on the part of either the clients themselves or others. This is critical to relapse prevention, as the most common relapse triggers are relationship difficulties, most often due to poor communication. Follow-up for this exercise could include guided practice in couples or family therapy, keeping a journal about outcomes of this assignment, and reporting back to the counselor and treatment group on outcomes.

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Saying what you mean in a way that is respectful both to yourself and to others is a skill that can be learned, and so is hearing what others are trying to share with you. Effective communication requires two basic skills: (1) expressing yourself clearly and (2) listening actively. In this exercise you will learn how to communicate more effectively and how to teach this to others.

1. Please list the people with whom you have the most trouble communicating and why you think this happens. Then do the same for people with whom you find it easy to communicate.

People With Whom It's Hard to Talk**Why It's Hard**

People With Whom It's Easy to Talk**Why It's Easy**

2. Now we will examine some communication styles and how they work. Although we all use different communication styles in different situations, we each have a favored style we use the most. While you read about the following styles, think about your own habits and those of other people in your life.

- a. *Aggressive.* Expressing yourself with an attitude of intimidation; little regard for others' rights, thoughts, or feelings. Aggressive communication can be abusive, threatening, and judgmental, and may include name-calling, yelling, interrupting, sarcasm, ridicule, and hostile body language.

- b. *Passive-aggressive.* Not expressing yourself openly, but instead hinting, being indirect, or being silent about what you want, think, or feel; talking behind others' backs; being sarcastic; pouting; whining; constant complaining; expecting others to know what you think, feel, or want

without your telling them; refusing to talk even though you're obviously upset.

c. *Passive*. Not feeling that you have a right to feelings or opinions; don't express yourself in any way that might upset others, or possibly any way at all; giving short, uninformative answers; agreeing with whatever others say.

d. *Assertive*. Expressing your thoughts, feelings, and wishes without ignoring those of others; being able to disagree openly and say "no" in a way that respects both others and oneself.

Which of the styles described above best describes your style of communication? Please choose one and give some examples of how you use this style.

3. In your relationships with family members, friends, and coworkers, what happens when you disagree with someone or someone disagrees with you?

4. When was the last time you disagreed with someone close to you? How did you handle the situation and how did the other person? What was the result?

5. Now we will look at the specific actions that make up effective communication and how you can use them:

- a. *Avoid mind-reading*. Don't tell the other person what he or she thinks and feels or what his or her reasons are for things he or she did. You might be right, but you might be misunderstanding. At any rate, most of us get angry or frustrated when others try to tell us what we think or feel, and this often triggers arguments or angry outbursts. *Usually when we mind-read we are not really trying to communicate, we are trying to dominate and control the other person, and no one wants to be dominated or controlled.* Think about the last time someone did this to you in a conversation. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.

- b. *No name-calling*. Usually when we are upset with someone it is because of something he or she did or didn't do: in other words, his or her actions. Calling someone a name is not referring to his or her actions, it is labeling who and what he or she is. This is frustrating for other people because they can change their actions, but they can't change who and what they are, and when we call them names, we're telling them that the things they can't change, who and what they are, are wrong or unacceptable. Besides this, name-calling is one of the most assured ways known to trigger anger in someone else and turn a discussion

into an argument or a fight. *Usually when we call someone a name, we are not trying to communicate, we are expressing anger and aggression, and the natural reaction on the other person's part is to become defensive and counterattack.* Think about the last time someone called you a name. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.

- c. *No interrupting and no long speeches.* These two guidelines go together. When we cut others off, including finishing their sentences for them, the message we are giving them is, "What you have to say is not important enough for any more of my time. Shut up! What I have to say is more important than your thoughts or feelings." Of course, for us to be willing to let the other person talk uninterrupted, we have to know that we will have a chance to express ourselves too. So if we want others to stop interrupting us, we have to give them their time to talk also. *Both interrupting and making long speeches are often ways to control others rather than ways to communicate effectively, and again, none of us like to be controlled by others.* Think about the last time someone went on and on in a conversation with you, or kept interrupting you. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.
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- d. *Be specific.* Again, we usually want someone to change an action and our chances of getting what we want are better the more we focus on his or her actions instead of on who and what he or she is. When we generalize, making statements such as "You always do _____" or "You never do _____," we are really labeling the person more than we are describing a specific action. We are also usually wrong. Even if he or she very often or very seldom does something, it is unlikely that he or she always or never does it—very few human beings are that consistent. He or she will be able to think of exceptions right away, and will probably feel hurt that we don't give him or her credit for those exceptions. This leads to an argument, not to a change in actions that helps us get along better. If we talk about a specific time, place, and event, it is easier to get to an agreement and change rather than an argument. *If we are generalizing, we are often labeling the person rather than the action, and are much more likely to trigger his or her defenses than to get him or her to make a change we want.* Think about the last time someone generalized about your behavior in a conversation with you. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.
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- e. *Stick close to the present.* We may still be feeling angry and hurt over things that happened a long time ago. But if we bring them up in a discussion of something we want to change now, it is more likely to make the other person feel the situation is hopeless than to get the change we want. He or she can't change what he or she did a long time ago. He or she can admit it and apologize for it, but that works best if it happens in a separate discussion. Especially if someone really is trying to change, it frustrates him or her if we keep criticizing him or her for things he or she did before. To keep tempers under control and avoid turning a discussion into an argument, don't bring up ancient history. *When we keep dragging up old grievances, it means we haven't finished dealing with them yet, but this is out of place in a talk about the present and future. It works better to get the present and future taken care of first, then go back and deal with the old problems.* Think about the last time someone brought up old issues in a conversation with you. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.
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- f. *Talk about one thing at a time.* We may have many problems to work out with another person, but if we try to work them all out at once the other person will feel overwhelmed. Most of us want to get along with others and we want them to tell us what they want from us. But if we feel they want more than we can do, we tend to feel frustrated rather than encouraged. When we start bringing up one thing after another in a discussion and throwing them at the other person, it is usually because we want to vent our frustration. This is sometimes called "kitchen-sink fighting" because it seems to him or her that we are throwing everything at him or her, including the kitchen sink. *If we really want to solve a particular problem with another person, we are most likely to succeed by keeping our focus on that problem. We may need to vent our frustrations over other things too, but it works better if we don't do it at the same time we are trying to solve this problem.* Think about the last time someone "threw the kitchen sink" at you in a discussion by throwing in unrelated issues. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.
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- g. *Claim your own feelings and actions.* A near-guaranteed way to pick a fight is to blame

another person for our own feelings or actions, by saying “You made me feel _____” or “You made me do _____.” Other people can’t make us do anything, unless they use physical force. We choose our actions based on our feelings, thoughts, and wishes. Others can’t even make us feel or think a certain way. Our feelings are our own. This is good! Otherwise, we could never be happy if anyone wanted to make us unhappy. Turn it around: Do you want to be blamed for someone else’s actions and feelings? Do you have enough control over anyone else to accept responsibility for what he or she does and feels? Or does he or she sometimes feel or act in ways you don’t want him or her to? To avoid this way to start a fight, it works better to say something like “When you did _____, it caused _____ to happen, and I felt _____.” Think about the last time someone blamed you for his or her feelings or actions. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.

- h. *Get and give frequent feedback.* It is easy to for us to misunderstand each other. It is very useful to check with the other person to make sure he or she understood what you meant. When the other person is talking, it is equally useful to make sure we understand him or her. The best way is for the listener to repeat the speaker’s message in his or her own words rather than repeating exactly the same words. The speaker can tell the listener that he or she has it right, or correct anything that was misunderstood. This also shows the other person that you are listening and understand him or her, and that makes most of us feel good. A key point is that you don’t have to agree with the other person’s point of view to give him or her feedback—all you are doing is letting him or her know you understand him or her. If you disagree, you will have a chance to say so soon. *Getting and giving feedback to make sure you are communicating clearly can avoid a lot of misunderstandings.* Think about the last time someone misunderstood something you were trying to say and didn’t check with you to clear it up. Describe that situation, how you felt, and whether you feel it helped the communication between you and the other person.

- i. *Respond to both the spoken and unspoken parts of the message.* As well as giving the other person feedback on his or her words, it is helpful to notice and respond to the feelings he or she seems to be expressing. If others see we are really paying attention and understanding them, they usually respond favorably. Think about the last time someone noticed your feelings as well as your words. How did he or she let you know, and how did you feel about it?

j. *Use a structured communication method.*

- (1) Agree to talk about the issue at a time and place that is practical for both people and as free of distractions as possible. If one wants to talk right away and the other doesn't, agree on a specific time in the near future.
- (2) Agree on who will talk first and who will listen first (you'll trade places often).
- (3) The first person makes a short statement, following the guidelines for effective communication (in other words, avoiding "fighting words"), and using this format:

EVENT / RESULT / FEELINGS

"When (event) happened / you did (action), it caused (result),/and I felt (feelings)."

Think about a recent time when you were upset with someone and use this space to write down what you might have said to express your viewpoint in this format.

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- (4) The second person responds with "I hear you telling me that . . ." and puts the message into his or her own words.
 - (5) The first person either agrees that the second person got the message right, restates any part that was left out or mixed up, or deletes anything that got added.
 - (6) Trade places and repeat the process. After the first time, you may switch to telling one another what you would like the other person to do or stop doing, in plain English. Just say "I would like you to _____." The feedback steps work the same as before.
 - (7) If you are not willing or able to do what the other person wants, tell him or her so in plain English: "I am not willing to _____ / I can't because _____." If possible, offer a compromise. Think about the last time someone wanted you to do something you were unable or unwilling to do, and use this space to write how you could have expressed this to the other person.
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- (8) Keep repeating this process until you both feel you clearly understand each other's perceptions, feelings, wants, and what you are willing to do for each other.

6. Most of these communication techniques are difficult to remember and practice at first but get easier with practice. It is helpful to practice them with the most important people in our lives, since those are the relationships in which good communication is most important. Part of your homework for this exercise is to talk about this with at least two important people in your life, practice with them, and talk about the results with your therapist and/or your therapy group. Who would be the best people for you to practice these methods with?

7. After thinking about and practicing these communication techniques, what questions do you want to ask your therapist about effective communication?
